Cost Per Accepted Change

A one-page worksheet for the true cost of producing trusted software in the AI-augmented era.

$$\frac{\text{model cost} + \text{infrastructure cost} + \text{engineering time} + \text{review cost} + \text{rework cost}}{\text{accepted changes}}$$

An *accepted change* is one that reached production — and stayed there.

Fill it in (per sprint, month, or release):

Model / API cost (LLM tokens, agent runs)	$
Infrastructure cost (CI, sandboxes, compute)	$
Engineering time (hours × loaded rate)	$
Review + verification cost (reviewer hours × rate)	$
Rework cost (fixing or reverting changes that did not stay)	$
TOTAL COST (A)	**$**

Accepted changes (denominator)

Changes that reached production ______
Minus reverted / rolled back / abandoned ______
ACCEPTED CHANGES (B) ______

Cost per accepted change = A ÷ B = $ ______

How to read it

- **Track it over time.** A rising number means each trustworthy change is costing you more.
- **Compare AI-assisted work against your baseline** — raw output can climb while this quietly does too.
- **Watch the rework row.** It is where unverified AI speed turns back into cost.

Originally defined in *The Delivery Gap* (Brenn Hill, 2026) as the cost vertex of the Verification Triangle.